

top B-schools in India consider as a benchmark for MBA admissions. “CAT-bias is definitely there. And when you go to lower-ranked B-schools, they take admissions through CAT, MAT (Management Aptitude Test), ATMA (AIMS Test for Management Admissions), and many other exam scores, so naturally, the pool of female candidates improves,” says Sangeeta Shah Bhardwaj, Acting Director of Management Development Institute (MDI) Gurgaon. Consequently, lower ranked B-schools show better gender ratios compared to the top B-schools in the country. “If your input is biased and skewed, then your output will also be skewed. So, one of the reasons why the gender ratio is not improving is the skewed input; for example, the CAT-bias,” she adds. “However, most of the B-schools are trying to improve that ratio by supporting gender diversity, by giving some weightage to female students, or some other type of initiative.”

Suresh K. Jakhar, Associate Professor at IIM Lucknow (IIML) feels that the CAT slightly favours students from engineering backgrounds or those with good quantitative aptitude. “That’s why male engineers perform well in CAT, draw a percentile and there, the representation of women is usually not as expected. Over time there has been a lot of discussion about CAT and we are continuously analysing and updating the exam,” he says. But according to him, the problem

is deeper than just the CAT-bias. “In India, a major part of the country still lives in Tier II and III cities and villages. The mindset of families towards the girl child doing an MBA and working in a corporate, is missing,” he adds. “The problem lies at the grass-roots level, at the school level. Very few women will go to senior secondary school. We need to be more focussed on school education of women.”

Jakhar’s deduction points towards the right direction. The low gender ratios in top Indian B-schools is because of an intersection of social, cultural and institutional factors, such as cultural biases that assign traditional gender roles, societal expectations, and a lack of support systems—both economic and academic.

But that doesn’t mean it’s all gloom and doom. Bhardwaj says that in just the past two years, she has seen the gender ratio at her institute improve substantially. “Two years ago, the ratio was 25 per cent. This year, it’s 67 per cent. It’s a big jump and it has happened because of our policies,” she says proudly.

Sougata Ray, Professor of Strategy and Entrepreneurship Practice, and Chair Professor and Executive Director, Thomas Schmidheiny Centre for Family Enterprise at Indian School of Business (ISB), says that as a first response to improve the gender

A Long Road Ahead

India’s dismal performance on various gender parity indicators results in the minuscule number of women students finding a place in the competitive landscape of admissions to top B-schools

	Overall Rankings	Economic Participation and Opportunity	Educational Attainment	Health and Survival	Political Empowerment
Germany	10	75	81	70	8
UK	22	44	33	105	24
US	27	22	51	83	38
China	102	37	120	145	120
Japan	116	121	1	63	139
India	135	143	107	146	48

PERFORMANCE OF THE TOP 5 ECONOMIES AND INDIA ON THE GLOBAL GENDER GAP INDEX THAT BENCHMARKS 146 COUNTRIES ON FOUR PARAMETERS OF GENDER PARITY; **SOURCE:** WEF’S GLOBAL GENDER GAP REPORT 2022